Munro was well aware of the religious sensitivities of the Brahmins, but also of their exactions. In a bid to reduce the power of the Nambudiris he recommended that the self-regulated Devaswom or ‘property of God’ bodies that traditionally administered each temple should all be taken over by the central governments of Cochin and Travancore, along with all their properties, and their revenues treated as part of the state’s revenues. This was much resented in some quarters but in Travancore Munro’s scheme was accepted and a Travancore Devaswom Board was set up to control most, but not all, of the kingdom’s temples. In Cochin there was greater opposition and the process was only partially implemented, and not fully realised until 1916. Here, I would argue, lies the real source of the continuing animosity in religious circles in Kerala towards John Munro.

In 1813 the Travancore queen gave birth to a son and heir, but after the birth of a second son a year later her health deteriorated, and she died in 1815. Her eldest boy was duly anointed Raja Karthika Thirumal Rama Varma, with his older sister acting as regent during his minority after the death of their mother. Munro himself had stepped down as Dewan of Travancore and Cochin shortly before the death of Rani Lakshmi Bayi and was replaced by two of his assistants, thereby setting a valuable precedent whereby the Dewans of both kingdoms were imported from outside, usually in the form of highly educated and experienced Tamil Brahmins from the Madras Presidency.

I should like to have ended this brief account of Munro’s eight years in Travancore by saying that when he embarked for Scotland in January 1819 he left its people in a happier state. But these were hard times, partly as a consequence of the Tambora volcanic eruption of 1815, east of Java, which disrupted weather patterns for some five years and had a devastating impact on much of Asia, leading to droughts, floods and widespread famines accompanied by